

» BEST OF 2025 A RARE HAT-TRICK

Suruchi Singh is another shooter who fashioned a landmark 2025. Few athletes announce themselves at the senior international level and rise to World No. 1 in under five months, but the 19-year-old from Haryana's Jhajjar did precisely that.

From the same district that produced double Olympic medallist Manu Bhaker, Suruchi's ascent has been startling not just for its speed, but for its scale. She became the only Indian shooter to win three consecutive individual World Cup gold medals in a single season, a feat that eludes many across entire careers.

Her run began in April in Buenos Aires, where she clinched her maiden senior individual World Cup gold and paired with Olympian Saurabh Chaudhary to win mixed team bronze in the 10m air pistol. The momentum carried seamlessly to Lima. There, Suruchi outshot Bhaker to take individual gold and then overturned a deficit to secure mixed team gold alongside Saurabh.

By the time the circuit reached Munich in June, Suruchi was the shooter everyone was chasing. In a tense final against France's Camille Jedrzejewski, she held her nerve to fire a 10.5 with her 23rd and final shot, sealing a third

straight individual World Cup gold.

The Asian Championships proved relatively subdued by her own standards, yielding two bronze medals: one in the mixed team event with Saurabh and another in the women's team competition alongside Bhaker and Palak.

Suruchi saved her most emphatic statement for December's ISSF World Cup Final at the Lusail Shooting Complex. Against the sport's elite, she produced a junior world record score of 245.1, surpassing the long-standing mark of 244.7 set by Bhaker in 2019. It felt less like symbolism and more like succession.

Senior teammate Sainyam, also a finalist, finished 1.8 points behind to claim silver. Together, they ensured India recorded a double podium in the same event at the World Cup Final for the first time, underlining the country's growing depth in shooting.

Santadeep Dey